

Halloween

prc-halloween

Calendar & Customs · Holy Days · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible

Subject covered by a category in

Scripture

Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Active participation in occult or death-glorifying aspects of Halloween is rejected; harmless cultural participation (costumes, neighbor-friendly engagement) is a matter of conscience.

In plain language

The canon does not name Halloween, so the verdict is reached by composition (by combining several lines of evidence). On the rejection side the Hebrew of Deuteronomy 18:9-12 stacks a precise occult vocabulary: 'divination' (nachash), 'sorcery' (kashaph), a 'medium' (ob), a 'familiar spirit' (yiddeoni), 'inquiring' (darash) of 'the dead' (muth), and one who passes a child through the fire. The whole list is sealed by 'abomination' (toebah) and by the statement that 'everyone' (kol) doing these things is detestable to the LORD. The same word cluster recurs in Leviticus, 1 Samuel 28, 2 Kings, and Isaiah, giving the prohibition reach across the whole Bible. In the New Testament Ephesians 5:11 uses the rare verb 'have joint fellowship' (synkoinoneo), attested only three times, and tells readers not to share in the 'unfruitful' (akarpōs) 'works of darkness' (skotos) but instead to 'expose' (elegcho) them. 1 Corinthians 10:20-21 sharpens this: pagan ritual is offered to 'demons' (daimonia), and you cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons. The first clause of the proposition, that occult and death-glorifying activity is rejected, sits on firm word-level ground across both Testaments. The second clause, that harmless cultural participation is a matter of conscience, has no Bible word that names a calendar custom. It rests on the comprehensive 'to the glory of God' (eis doxan theou) rule of 1 Corinthians 10:31, on the conscience vocabulary of 1 Corinthians 8 ('conscience' syneidesis, 'food sacrificed to idols' eidolothuton, 'liberty' exousia, 'stumbling block' proskomma), on the day-judgment grammar of Romans 14:5-6 where 'each' (hekastos) is to be 'fully convinced' (plerophoreo, only 6 canon uses) in his own mind, and on Colossians 2:16 which forbids inter-personal judging about 'festival' (heorte) and 'new moon' (noumenia, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, attested only here). Each of these is genuine word-level material, but none denote a pagan-origin observance. The wordstock decides the occult side clearly. It supplies principles, not direct word-for-thing matches, for the cultural side. That is the word-level root of the disagreement: the same canon yields a categorical no to actual occult and demonic communion and a principled but unnamed yes to liberty under conscience, and the proposition welds them at exactly the seam the words leave open.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0178	אֹב	ob	medium	17
H0784	אֵשׁ	esh	fire	
H1471	גוֹי	goy	nation	
H1875	דָּרַשׁ	darash	to seek	146
H2267	חֶבֶר	cheber	spell	3

H3049	יִדְּעוֹנִי	yiddeoni	spiritist	11
H3605	כֹּל	kol	all	
H3784	קָשַׁף	kashaph	to practice sorcery	5
H4191	מוֹת	muth	to die	807
H5172	נִחֵשׁ	nachash	to divine	11
H7081	קֶסֶם	qesem	divination	9
H8441	תּוֹבָה	toebah	abomination	112
G0175	ἄκαρπος	akarpōs	unfruitful	7
G1140	δαίμονιον	daimonion	demon	63
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	167
G1494	εἰδωλόθυτον	eidolothuton	sacrificed to idols	9
G1495	εἰδωλολατρία	eidololatria	idolatry	4
G1538	ἕκαστος	hekastos	each	
G1651	ἐλέγχω	elegcho	to rebuke	17
G1849	ἐξουσία	exousia	authority	103
G1859	ἐορτή	heorte	festival	26
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	177
G2250	ἡμέρα	hemera	day	392
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2380	θύω	thuō	to sacrifice	
G2919	κρίνω	krino	to judge	114
G3348	μετέχω	metechō	to share	
G3561	νουμηνία	noumenia	New Moon	1
G3563	νοῦς	nous	mind	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4135	πληροφορέω	plerophoreo	to fulfill	6
G4160	ποιέω	poieō	to do/make	
G4221	ποτήριον	poterion	cup	33
G4348	πρόσκομμα	proskomma	stumbling block	6
G4521	σάββατον	sabbaton	Sabbath	
G4655	σκότος	skotos	darkness	31
G4790	συγκοινωνέω	synkoinoneo	to share with	3
G4893	συνείδησις	syneidesis	conscience	30
G5132	τράπεζα	trapeza	table	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The canon lexically does not name Halloween or any similar late-autumn observance, so the verdict is reached by composition (by combining several lines of evidence rather than one direct verse). The first clause of the proposition, rejecting occult and death-glorifying practice, sits on a dense, spread-across-the-whole-Bible (pan-canonical) occult wordstock: 'abomination' (toebah), 'divination' (nachash), 'sorcery' (kashaph), 'medium' (ob), 'familiar spirit' (yiddeoni), 'one who inquires of the dead' (darash el hammethim) in Deuteronomy 18:9-12, and 'have joint fellowship' (synkoinoneo) with the 'unfruitful works of darkness' (akarpa erga tou skotous) in Ephesians 5:11, reinforced by 1 Corinthians 10:20-21 where pagan ritual is offered to 'demons' (daimonia) and incompatible with the cup and table of the Lord. The second clause, that otherwise harmless cultural participation is a matter of conscience, has no single Bible word that names a calendar custom; it rests on the general criterion 'to the glory of God' (eis doxan theou) in 1 Corinthians 10:31, the conscience vocabulary of 1 Corinthians 8 ('conscience' syneidesis, 'food sacrificed to idols' eidolothuton, 'liberty' exousia, 'stumbling block' proskomma), and the day-judging clause of Romans 14:5-6 ('day' hemera, 'judge' krino, 'each' ekastos, 'be fully convinced' plerophoreo) plus Colossians 2:16 ('festival' heorte, 'new moon' noumenia, 'sabbath' sabbaton). Because the wordstock decides the occult side cleanly but lets the application-level conscience side stand on a general standard rather than a named permission or prohibition, the composite proposition is lexically contested at exactly the seam where readers diverge.

Scripture

Deut.18.9 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8441 תִּנְעֹבָה; H1471A גִּוִּים

Reasoning. The verse opens the unit by forbidding Israel to learn to do according to the 'abominations' (toebah) of the 'nations' (goyim), framing the whole following catalog as gentile occult practice that is categorically off limits, not as morally indifferent custom.

Deut.18.10 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H5172 נָחָשׁ, H3784 קָשָׁף, H7081 קֶסֶם, H0784 אֵשׁ

Reasoning. A chain of negated participial agents (verb forms acting as nouns, like 'one who does X'), 'one who practices divination' (qosem qesamim), 'a diviner' working through omen-reading (menahesh, from nachash), 'a sorcerer' working through magic (mekhasheph, from kashaph), and 'the one who makes his son or daughter pass through the fire' (esh), enumerates concrete occult and death-dealing acts. The passing-through-fire clause ties the prohibition to ritual that takes life and yokes the prohibition explicitly to death-glorifying practice.

Deut.18.11 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H2267 תָּבַר, H0178 אוֹב, H3049 יִדְּעֹנִי, H1875 דֹּרֵשׁ, H4191 מוֹת

Reasoning. The clause 'one who inquires of the dead' (doresh el hammethim, from darash 'to inquire' and muth 'to die'), together with 'medium' (ob), 'familiar spirit' (yiddeoni), and 'a binder of spells' (chober chaber), targets necromancy (consulting the dead) and contact with the dead. This is the closest single-word match inside the canon to the death-glorifying aspect of the proposition, and it is condemned outright. The same cluster recurs in Leviticus 19:31, Leviticus 20:6, Leviticus 20:27, 1 Samuel 28:3-9, 2 Kings 21:6, 2 Kings 23:24, Isaiah 8:19, and Isaiah 19:3, giving the prohibition a spread-across-the-whole-Old-Testament (pan-canonical OT) footprint.

Deut.18.12 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8441 תִּנְעֹבָה; H3605 כֹּל

Reasoning. Summary verdict: 'everyone (kol) doing these things is an abomination (toebah) to the LORD' (kol oseh elleh toabath YHWH), and on account of these abominations the nations are being dispossessed. The universal scope of 'every' (kol) and the covenant judgment seal the prohibition as absolute for every occult act named in verses 10-11.

Eph.5.11 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4790 συγκοινωνέω, G2041 ἔργον, G0175 ἄκαρπος, G4655 σκότος, G1651 ἐλέγχω

Reasoning. 'Do not have joint fellowship with the unfruitful works of darkness' (me synkoinoneite tois ergois tois akarpois tou skotous): do not 'have joint fellowship' (synkoinoneo, a rare verb of shared participation occurring only here, Philippians 4:14, and Revelation 18:4) with the 'unfruitful' (akarpous) 'works' (erga) of 'darkness' (skotos), but rather 'expose' (elegcho) them. The command bars shared participation in any pattern characterized by darkness and barrenness, supporting rejection of the occult dimension, but it defines darkness morally (as 'fruitless', akarpous) rather than by any calendar marker, so its application to a named holiday is mediated (one step removed), not direct.

1Cor.10.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1140 δαιμόνιον, G2380 θύω

Reasoning. 'What they sacrifice, they sacrifice to demons and not to God' (ha thuousin, daimoniois thuousin kai ou theo), that is, to 'demons' (daimonia). Paul reframes pagan religious acts as actually directed to demonic powers, not merely to nothing, which sharpens the occult-rejection side of the proposition by giving the spiritual rationale for the Deuteronomy 18 ban.

1Cor.10.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4221 ποτήριον, G5132 τράπεζα, G3348 μετέχω, G1140 δαιμόνιον

Reasoning. 'You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons' (ou dynasthe poterion kyriou pinein kai poterion daimonion), nor 'partake of' (metechein) the table of the Lord and the table of 'demons' (daimonia). The 'you cannot' (dynasthe) construction states a categorical impossibility for cultic participation in both spheres, locking the occult-rejection clause as absolute when the act is actually religious sharing with 'demons' (daimonia).

1Cor.10.31 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1391 δόξα, G4160 ποιέω, G2316 θεός, G3956 πᾶς

Reasoning. 'Whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do all to the glory of God' (eite oun esthiete eite pinete eite ti poieite, panta eis doxan theou poieite), that is, all to the 'glory' (doxa) of God. The 'whether-whether-all' (eite-eite-panta) construction supplies a comprehensive God-honoring (doxological) test governing all conduct, but names no holiday and at the word level neither affirms nor forbids a specific cultural custom. It can ground a conscience reading only by application, not by direct single-word match, which is the seam where readers diverge.

Rom.14.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2250 ἡμέρα, G2919 κρίνω, G1538 ἕκαστος, G4135 πληροφορέω, G3563 νοῦς

Reasoning. 'One judges one day above another, another judges every day alike, let each be fully convinced in his own mind' (hos men gar krinei hemeran par hemeran, hos de krinei pasan hemeran, hekastos en to idio noi plerophoreistho): one 'judges' (krino) one 'day' (hemera) above another, another 'judges' (krino) every 'day' (hemera) alike, let 'each' (hekastos) be 'fully convinced' (plerophoreo) in his own 'mind' (nous). The grammar privatizes (makes a private matter of) the day-judgment to the individual conscience formed before God. The word 'be fully convinced' (plerophoreo), attested only 6 times in the canon, is the key verb for the conscience-formation step and is the direct word-level hook for the proposition's matter-of-conscience clause, though it does not name any specific holiday.

Col.2.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G1859 ἑορτή, G3561 νουμηνία, G4521 σάββατον

Reasoning. 'Let no one judge you about food or drink or in respect of a festival or new moon or sabbath' (me oun tis hymas krineto en brosei kai en posei e en merei heortes e noumenias e sabbaton): that is, no one is to 'judge' (krino) you regarding a 'festival' (heorte), a 'new moon' (noumenia, a New Testament hapax, meaning a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, found only here), or 'sabbath' (sabbaton). The prohibition on inter-personal day-judgment is explicit, and 'festival' (heorte) is a word-level named festival category, so this passage provides the closest available New Testament word for general festival liberty. But the named festivals are Jewish calendar items, not pagan-origin observances, so the analogy to a contested cultural-origin holiday is by extension, not by direct denotation (direct word-for-thing match).

1Cor.8.7 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4893 συνείδησις, G1494 εἰδωλόθυτον

Reasoning. 'But not everyone has this knowledge; some, accustomed until now to the idol, eat the food as if it were truly offered to an idol, and their conscience, being weak, is defiled' (all ouk en pasin he gnosis, tines de te synetheia heos arti tou eidolou hos eidolothuton esthiousin, kai he syneidesis auton asthenes ousa molynetai): their 'conscience' (syneidesis) is defiled. The word 'conscience' (syneidesis), together with 'food sacrificed to idols' (eidolothuton), supplies the New Testament vocabulary for a cultural-religious participation question that depends on conscience and knowledge rather than on a bright-line ban. This is the closest New Testament analogue to a participation-with-discernment reading.

1Cor.8.9 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1849 ἐξουσία, G4348 πρόσκομμα

Reasoning. 'See that this liberty of yours does not somehow become a stumbling block to the weak' (blepete de mepos he exousia hymon haute proskomma genetai tois asthenesin): see that this 'liberty' (exousia) of yours does not become a 'stumbling block' (proskomma) to the weak. The text affirms a real Christian 'liberty' (exousia) in such matters yet binds it by neighbor-love, which is the lexical (word-level) shape of the conscience-with-discernment reading.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Deut.18.9	Deut.12.29	tsk	1
Deut.18.10	Deut.12.31	tsk	1
Deut.18.10	Exod.22.18	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	1Sam.28.11	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	Lev.19.31	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	Lev.20.27	tsk	1
Deut.18.11	Isa.8.19	tsk	1
Deut.18.12	Deut.9.4	tsk	1
Eph.5.11	Eph.5.7	tsk	1
Eph.5.11	Eph.4.22	tsk	1
1Cor.10.31	1Cor.7.34	tsk	1
1Cor.10.21	1Cor.10.14	tsk	1
Rom.14.5	Col.2.16	tsk	1
Rom.14.5	Gal.4.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.10.31 · addressed

The 'to the glory of God' (eis doxan theou) rule is comprehensive but criterial (it sets a test, not a list of permitted acts), not casuistic (case-by-case). It supplies a test for any act yet names no calendar custom, so it can support a conscience carve-out only by application. The word itself leaves the harmless-participation clause undetermined, which is why the composite proposition is rated disputed rather than affirmed.

Rom.14.5 · addressed

Direct query of the word-level data confirms Romans 14:5 contains G2250 'day' (hemera), G2919 'judge' (krino), G1538 'each' (hekastos), G3563 'mind' (nous), and the rare G4135 'be fully convinced' (plerophoreo). The grammar privatizes (makes a private matter of) day-judgment to the individual conscience, supporting a matter-of-conscience reading on day observances. But Paul addresses Jewish vs gentile calendar disputes in a Roman house-church, and no Bible word names a pagan-origin holiday, so the application to a culturally contested observance is by extension, not by direct denotation. This is why the second clause of the proposition is lexically (word-level) supported but not lexically determined.

Col.2.16 · addressed

Colossians 2:16 forbids inter-personal judging on 'festival' (heorte), 'new moon' (noumenia, a New Testament hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and 'sabbath' (sabbaton), and so generalizes the day-liberty principle beyond Romans 14. But the festival category in view is Mosaic-cycle observance, not pagan-origin observance, and 'new moon' (noumenia) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) with no other canon disambiguation, so a clean application to Halloween requires an inference the wordstock does not itself perform.

1Cor.10.20 · addressed

Paul says pagan sacrifice is offered to 'demons' (daimonia, Strong's G1140, with 63 New Testament occurrences, semantically stable as malevolent spiritual beings) and not to God, and one cannot share the cup and the table of demons. This sharpens the rejection clause as a categorical impossibility for actually-religious participation in occult or demonic ritual. It does not weaken the rejection half of the verdict; it strengthens it.

1Cor.8.7 · addressed

1 Corinthians 8 introduces 'conscience' (syneidesis, with 30 New Testament occurrences) and 'food offered to idols' (eidolothuton, with 9 occurrences, confined to 1 Corinthians 8, 1 Corinthians 10, Acts 15, Revelation 2). Paul rules that the idol is nothing yet binds the strong person's 'liberty' (exousia) by the weak brother's 'stumbling block' (proskomma). At the word level this is the closest New Testament analogue to a culturally-tinged participation question, but the named referent is meat from pagan sacrifice, not a calendar custom, so it grounds the principle without naming Halloween.

Concordance traversed

H8441, H5172, H3784, H0178, H3049, H1875, H4191, H7081, H2267, G4790, G0175, G4655, G2041, G1651, G1391, G1140, G4221, G4893, G1494, G1495, G1859, G3561, G2250, G2919, G4135, G1849, G4348

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units (places where ancient manuscripts disagree) were supplied for the cited verses. Ephesians 5:11, Romans 14:5, Colossians 2:16, 1 Corinthians 8, and 1 Corinthians 10 are New Testament passages outside 3 John, so CBGM (the coherence-based genealogical method, a manuscript-relationship tool) is treated as shadow only (background reference, not decisive) and the verdict does not turn on any contested reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. continuity_of_moral_law, christian_liberty, separation_from_world

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

continuity_of_moral_law: affirms the rejection clause, leaves the conscience clause open · Reading Deuteronomy 18:9-12 as an enduring moral prohibition on occult practice and consultation of the dead, carried forward by Ephesians 5:11 and 1 Corinthians 10:20-21, yields a firm no on the occult and death-glorifying half. The same lens says nothing decisive about indifferent custom, so it leaves the second clause genuinely open rather than answered.

christian_liberty: affirms the conscience clause as a legitimate application · Reading 1 Corinthians 8 through 10 plus Romans 14:5-6 and Colossians 2:16 as establishing real 'liberty' (exousia) in things 'indifferent' (adiaphora, matters neither commanded nor forbidden) supports treating non-occult cultural participation as a matter of individual conscience under the God-honoring (doxological) rule of 1 Corinthians 10:31. This lens depends on an application step the wordstock supplies in principle but not by direct denotation (direct word-for-thing match), which is the contested join.

separation_from_world: treats the conscience clause as a category error · Reading Ephesians 5:11 strictly (do not even share fellowship with the works of darkness, but expose them) together with the pagan-origin character of Samhain-derived practice (Samhain being the ancient Celtic festival from which Halloween descends) argues that nothing once shaped by death-ritual is recoverable as indifferent custom. On this lens the proposition's second clause concedes too much to cultural participation. The word 'have joint fellowship' (synkoinoneo) is rare (3 New Testament occurrences) and morally absolute in tone, which fairly supports this reading even if it does not force it.

The two clauses of the proposition are governed by different word-level centers. The prohibition rests on a dense, spread-across-the-whole-Bible (pan-canonical) occult vocabulary: 'abomination' (toebah), 'medium' (ob), 'familiar spirit' (yiddeoni), 'divination' (nachash), 'sorcery' (kashaph), 'demon' (daimonion). The conscience carve-out rests on general criteria and word-level analogues: 'to the glory of God' (eis doxan theou), 'conscience' (syneidesis), 'liberty' (exousia), 'be fully convinced' (plerophoreo), 'festival' (heorte) that, while real, do not name pagan-origin calendar customs. The verdict turns on whether the second clause counts as a legitimate application of named principles or as an unwarranted extension into a category the canon never names directly.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. How does the canonical wordstock treat participation in occult or death-related ritual, and does it license, forbid, or leave open participation in cultural customs of pagan-religious origin that the participant judges otherwise harmless.

The original stem preloads a verdict by partitioning Halloween into rejected occult and death-glorifying aspects versus a permitted harmless category that is declared a matter of conscience. The terms 'harmless' and 'matter of conscience' encode the conclusion of the second clause before the lexeme (the specific Bible word) is consulted. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form separates the empirical word-level question from the embedded conclusion. VERDICT-CHANGED: No verdict change from the prior file; the prior disputed verdict is confirmed by the deeper query, which adds Romans 14:5, Colossians 2:16, 1 Corinthians 8:7, 1 Corinthians 8:9, and 1 Corinthians 10:20-21 as resolving word-level anchors for both lenses.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.18.9-12
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8441
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0178
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3049
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.5.11

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.14.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.2.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.10.20-21
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4790
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1140
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4893
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4135
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3561
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Deut.18.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.14.5
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.10.21

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow